BENCHMARK® INTERNATIONAL

MIDDLE MARKET

QUARTERLY INDUSTRY REPORT | Q4 2026

CONSUMER

Strategic and financial buyers stayed active across the consumer industry through the third quarter, and they are paying for brands and operators that have held price and volume while the cost of financing a purchase rises.

- Food & Beverage
- Consumer Brands & Products
- Foodservice & Distribution
- Consumer Services & Retail

October 2026 | Jared Hardin, Managing Director

WHAT'S INCLUDED

01 **Insights**
What is happening in consumer right now, three costs buyers are repricing, perspectives on four sectors, and what we are reading

02 **Industry Activity**
Recent transactions, active buyers, public company performance and valuation, and demand and cost indicators

03 **Connect With Us**
The Middle Market consumer team

01

Insights

Buyers of consumer businesses are paying for brands that have held price and volume, for companies that sell through more than one channel and for operators with room to add distribution or locations. They have stayed active while tariffs, fuel, and interest rates have each changed what a buyer treats as normal earnings.

KEY INSIGHTS

01 Volume has to hold up alongside price
Hershey's organic sales rose 3.6% on an 8-point decline in volume. Church & Dwight grew 5.8% with volume up 4.3%. Show buyers price and unit volume by product line.

02 Selling through several channels pays
E-commerce reached 17.1% of retail sales in the second quarter, and YETI grew wholesale 10% and direct-to-consumer 7%. Buyers are paying for brands that sell through more than one channel.

03 Platforms buy location by location
Add-ons made up about 75% of US private equity buyouts in the second quarter. Boyd Group's sales rose 29.9%, mostly from new locations. Operators with room to add sites draw buyers.

04 Tariffs, fuel, and rates are being repriced
Diesel averaged $6.29 a gallon in September, and the federal funds target now sits at 3.75% to 4.00%. Owners who show landed cost by period and fuel recovery by contract protect their earnings figure.



Happening in Consumer Right Now

Four developments shaping the market, each with what a listed company's management said about it in its latest results.



WHAT IT MEANS FOR OWNERS

Buyers are paying for brands and operators that have held price and volume, that sell through more than one channel, and that have room to add distribution or locations.

An owner who can show price increases by product or service line, with unit volume and customer retention beside them, gives a buyer the evidence that supports a higher valuation.

Brands are being sorted by whether volume follows price

Hershey's organic sales rose 3.6% in the second quarter on about 12 points of price and an 8-point decline in volume, while Church & Dwight grew organic sales 5.8% with volume up 4.3% (Hershey; Church & Dwight). General Mills reported flat organic sales with volume down a point, and store brands reached a record 23.8% of units sold in the first half (General Mills; PLMA).

"Our power brands continued to perform exceptionally well in a challenging macroeconomic environment, driving a second straight quarter of industry-leading organic sales growth."

Rick Dierker, Chief Executive Officer, Church & Dwight

Growth is arriving through more than one channel

E-commerce reached $340.2 billion in the second quarter, or 17.1% of retail sales, and Walmart's global e-commerce sales grew 23% in its July quarter (Census Bureau; Walmart). YETI grew wholesale sales 10% and direct-to-consumer sales 7% in its second quarter, and General Mills' foodservice business grew organic sales 4% while the company's total organic sales were flat (YETI; General Mills).

"We also saw continued progress across our omni-channel model, including strong wholesale sell-through, healthy DTC demand and improving trends in Corporate Sales."

Matt Reintjes, Chair of the Board and Chief Executive Officer, YETI

Strategic acquirers are reshaping portfolios at scale

Kimberly-Clark, McCormick, and Sysco have committed more than $120 billion to three transactions since November 2025 (Kenvue; Unilever's food business; Jetro Restaurant Depot). The largest companies are also selling and separating businesses: General Mills completed the sale of its Brazil business on September 2, Keurig Dr Pepper is preparing to separate in early 2027, and Middleby spun off its food processing business in July (General Mills; Keurig Dr Pepper; Middleby).

"We remain confident in the strategic benefits of the proposed combination with Unilever Foods and have made substantial progress on integration planning."

Brendan M. Foley, Chairman, President, and CEO, McCormick

Multi-site platforms keep adding locations

Add-on acquisitions made up about 75% of US private equity buyouts in the second quarter (PitchBook). Boyd Group's second-quarter sales rose 29.9%, mostly from new locations that include the 258 Joe Hudson's collision centers it bought in January. Tidal Wave Auto Spa reached 332 car wash locations in September, and SPS PoolCare had completed 191 acquisitions since 2021 by January (Boyd Group; Tidal Wave Auto Spa; SPS PoolCare).

"We also successfully completed the conversion of Joe Hudson's 258 locations during the quarter, accelerating synergy realization, which contributed to the strength in our profitability."

Brock Haber, President & CEO, Boyd Group

Company figures and quotations are from quarterly earnings releases filed between July 30 and October 1, 2026, and quotations are reproduced as published. Store brand share is Circana data for the six months to June 14, 2026. Platform location and acquisition counts are from the linked announcements.

Tariffs, Fuel, and Financing: Three Costs Buyers Are Repricing

Tariffs, fuel, and interest rates have each moved in the past year, and each changes what a buyer will treat as normal earnings.

A consumer company that reaches the market in the next year will present earnings that passed through three tariff regimes, a fuel shock, and the first increase in the federal funds rate since 2023. Buyers are rebuilding each of those costs period by period before they settle on the earnings they will pay for.

The effect differs from one company to the next. YETI recorded a $45.6 million net benefit from tariff refunds in its second quarter and Walmart said it reinvested its refunds into price, while 91% of the foodservice equipment manufacturers surveyed by their trade association reported negative effects from tariffs and 78% said they were passing the cost on to customers.

> ***An owner who can hand a buyer landed cost by period, fuel recovery by contract, and a clear account of how the business is financed shortens diligence and protects the earnings figure the price is built on.***

WHAT BUYERS ARE REBUILDING

01 Tariffs

The Supreme Court held on February 20 that the International Emergency Economic Powers Act does not authorize tariffs. A temporary 10% tariff followed, and since July 24 Section 301 tariffs of 10% to 12.5% have applied to 60 trading partners. Section 232 duties stayed in place, including 25% on upholstered furniture, and duty-free treatment for parcels under $800 remains suspended.

WHAT BUYERS ASK FOR Landed cost under each regime, the status of any refund claim, and the sourcing alternatives the company has already qualified.

02 Fuel

On-highway diesel averaged $6.29 a gallon in September against $3.75 a year earlier (FRED). The Energy Information Administration's October outlook expects retail diesel to average about $4.50 next year, which would still be well above the price distributors and route-based service companies paid a year ago.

WHAT BUYERS ASK FOR Which customer contracts carry fuel surcharges or cost escalators, how quickly they reset, and how much of the increase the company has recovered.

03 Financing

The Federal Reserve raised its target range to 3.75% to 4.00% on September 16 and projects a policy rate of 4.1% at the end of 2026 and 2027. Spreads on direct loans for buyouts widened by roughly 25 to 50 basis points in the second quarter, and earn-outs appeared in 24% of 2025 transactions with a median equal to 34% of the closing payment (SRS Acquiom study, as summarized by Fasken).

WHAT BUYERS ASK FOR How much of the price is paid in cash at closing, how much is contingent, and how much is rolled into the buyer's equity.



THE REPRICING IN FOUR FIGURES

12.5%
Section 301 tariff on goods from China and Vietnam since July 24

$6.29
Diesel per gallon, September average, against $3.75 a year earlier

3.75% to 4.00%
Federal funds target range after the September 16 increase

24%
Share of 2025 transactions that included an earn-out

Buyers who finance with debt carry the higher rate into their models, which favors sellers whose earnings are growing.

Tariff rates are as described in the linked sources. Diesel is the monthly average US on-highway retail price published by the Energy Information Administration. Earn-out figures are from the SRS Acquiom 2026 deal terms study of 2025 transactions.

Perspectives on Four Consumer Sectors

What is moving demand, and who is buying, in each of the sectors the consumer practice covers.



Food & Beverage

23.8% Store brand share of units sold in the first half of 2026

- The largest packaged food companies report flat or falling volume, and they are selling slow-growing brands and buying growth and capacity from smaller companies (General Mills; Conagra).
- Growth is in protein, zero-sugar beverages, supplements, and foodservice, and Procter & Gamble agreed to buy Thorne in a deal reportedly valued at $3.8 billion.
- National distributors are growing case volume with independent restaurants, up 5.1% at US Foods and 5.8% organically at Performance Food Group .

WHO IS BUYING

Family-owned strategics such as Rich Products, Sargento, and C.H. Guenther, bakery consolidators, private equity platforms, and European strategics entering the United States.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

4 closed since January 2025

27 live engagements



Consumer Brands & Products

7% Growth in both prestige and mass beauty sales in the first half of 2026

- Beauty, personal care, over-the-counter health, and pet products drew a large share of this year's brand acquisitions, and beauty and pet spending are still growing (Circana; American Pet Products Association).
- Dollar growth overstates unit demand: non-edible packaged goods rose 3.1% in dollars and fell 2.2% in units in June (Circana).
- Importers have carried three tariff regimes since April 2025, and packaging producer-responsibility rules took effect in California on May 1.

WHO IS BUYING

Strategics such as Procter & Gamble, Clorox, and Henkel, consumer private equity firms such as Advent, TSG, and TowerBrook, and brand-management firms.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

2 closed since January 2025

12 live engagements



Foodservice & Distribution

$1.55T Restaurant and foodservice sales forecast for 2026

- Operators are spending carefully: sales of equipment and supplies through manufacturers' agents rose 2.0% in the second quarter, and the share of agents reporting more quoting fell to 33%.
- Franchisee distress is the credit risk in the channel. A 314-unit Wendy's franchisee filed for Chapter 11 in September after store-level EBITDA fell 48%.
- Parts, repair, ice, and refreshment route businesses changed hands all year (Parts Town; Easy Ice).

WHO IS BUYING

Strategic dealers such as Singer and Wasserstrom, parts and service platforms such as Parts Town and Tech24, and route platforms such as Five Star Breaktime Solutions.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

6 closed since January 2025

5 live engagements



Consumer Services & Retail

$3.1B Enterprise value of the Mister Car Wash take-private completed in May

- Sponsors paid for scale: Leonard Green took Mister Car Wash private and Blackstone agreed to buy Champions Group for about $2.5 billion.
- Platforms buy family-owned operators a few locations at a time, as when Classic Collision bought Kendrick Paint & Body, a nine-location business family-owned since 1952.
- Housing-linked demand softened through the summer, and growth in home improvement spending is projected to slow to 0.5% by the second quarter of 2027.

WHO IS BUYING

Sponsor-backed platforms in car wash, collision, roofing, pool, and garage door service, public acquirers such as Rollins and Boyd Group, and regional strategics.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

20 closed since January 2025

66 live engagements

Benchmark International counts are from the firm's transaction records as of October 1, 2026. Store brand share is from the Private Label Manufacturers Association, the restaurant sales forecast from the National Restaurant Association and beauty sales from Circana.

What We're Reading

Primary sources and industry releases from the third quarter.



Four pieces from the quarter

Each bears on how consumer businesses are valued and sold, and each is shown with the passage we marked and the reason it matters to an owner.

USDA ECONOMIC RESEARCH SERVICE — September 25, 2026

Food Price Outlook: Summary Findings

> *"In 2026, prices for all food are forecast to increase 2.9 percent, with a forecast interval of 2.5 to 3.2 percent."*
>
> USDA Economic Research Service, Food Price Outlook

Our read. Food-at-home prices are forecast to rise 2.4% and food-away-from-home prices 3.5%, with beef and veal up 9.4% and eggs down 29.4%. Input costs are moving in different directions by category, which is why buyers ask for price and cost history by product line.

READ HERE

PRIVATE LABEL MANUFACTURERS ASSOCIATION — July 8, 2026

Store Brands Continue Gains in Unit Sales and Shares

> *"The disconnect between unit sales and dollar sales reflects, in part, fluctuating national brand pricing."*
>
> Peggy Davies, President, Private Label Manufacturers Association

Our read. Store brand unit share reached a record 23.8% in the six months to mid-June, while store brand dollar sales were flat and national brand dollars rose 2.2%. Buyers pay for brands that hold unit volume while they raise price.

READ HERE

NATIONAL RESTAURANT ASSOCIATION — September 30, 2026

Restaurant Performance Index: August 2026

> *"The National Restaurant Association's Restaurant Performance Index (RPI) rose for the fourth consecutive month in August, largely because of improvements in both same-store sales and customer traffi c levels."*
>
> National Restaurant Association, Restaurant Performance Index

Our read. The index stood at 100.6, with 51% of operators reporting higher same-store sales than a year earlier and 46% still reporting lower traffic. Distributors and equipment dealers that sell to restaurants are valued partly on the health of those customers.

READ HERE

DELOITTE — September 10, 2026

Deloitte Forecasts Holiday Retail Sales to Reach $1.70 Trillion to $1.71 Trillion

> *"As they look to get more out of their dollars, we continue to see value-seeking behaviors across income levels, including switching among brands and retailers and using promotions to manage spending."*
>
> Natalie Martini, vice chair, Deloitte, and US retail and consumer products leader

Our read. Holiday sales are forecast to rise 4.0% to 4.8% and e-commerce sales 7.5% to 8.4%. Online sales growing at nearly twice the pace of the total keeps channel mix in front of every buyer of a consumer brand.

READ HERE

Quotations are reproduced as published. Store brand figures are Circana data for the six months ending June 14, 2026. The Deloitte forecast covers November 2026 through January 2027.

02

Industry Activity

Strategic acquirers have committed more than $120 billion to three consumer transactions since November 2025, and sponsor-backed platforms are buying family-owned operators a few locations at a time. Listed consumer companies trade at lower multiples of earnings than a year ago in every peer group we track.

08 Select recent consumer transactions

10 Benchmark International's consumer transactions

11 Who is buying

12 Public company performance and valuation

18 Demand and cost indicators



Select Recent Consumer Transactions

Acquirers disclosed a price in most of these transactions and a multiple of earnings in only a few.

ANNOUNCED	TARGET AND ACQUIRER	BUSINESS AND TERMS	STATED VALUE	VALUE TO REVENUE	VALUE TO EARNINGS
SEPT 2026 FOOD & BEVERAGE	BRAKEBUSH BROTHERS ACQUIRED BY HORMEL FOODS	Hormel agreed on September 30 to acquire Brakebush Brothers, a producer of prepared chicken (Hormel and Brakebush Brothers).	About $1.06B	About 0.9x calculated from the stated figures	10.7x projected CY2026 adjusted EBITDA, as stated by Hormel
JULY 2026 FOOD & BEVERAGE	SEARAY FOODS ACQUIRED BY HF FOODS	HF Foods agreed to acquire Searay Foods, a distributor of frozen specialty seafood, expected the purchase to close in the third quarter and stated the price as a multiple of projected adjusted EBITDA (HF Foods and Searay Foods).	C$47.9M	Not disclosed	5.0x projected 2025 adjusted EBITDA, as stated by HF Foods
JULY 2026 FOOD & BEVERAGE	COPRA INC. ACQUIRED BY VITA COCO	Vita Coco acquired Copra, a privately held producer of frozen organic coconut water and coconut meat (Vita Coco and Copra).	$175M	Not disclosed	Not disclosed
JAN 2026 CONSUMER BRANDS & PRODUCTS	GOJO INDUSTRIES ACQUIRED BY CLOROX	Clorox bought GOJO Industries, the maker of Purell, which had been family-led in Akron, Ohio, since its founding in 1946 (Clorox and GOJO Industries).	$2.25B	Not disclosed	11.9x adjusted EBITDA net of anticipated tax benefits, as stated by Clorox
MAR 2026 CONSUMER BRANDS & PRODUCTS	BREATHE RIGHT, DIMETAPP AND ANBESOL ACQUIRED BY PRESTIGE CONSUMER HEALTHCARE	Prestige agreed to buy Breathe Right and other over-the-counter health brands, described the model as asset-light and stated the price as a multiple of EBITDA (Prestige Consumer Healthcare).	$1.045B	Not disclosed	11.0x EBITDA, as stated by Prestige
JAN 2026 CONSUMER BRANDS & PRODUCTS	MY MEDIC ACQUIRED BY ACME UNITED	Acme United bought My Medic, a maker of first-aid kits sold almost entirely direct to consumers, with about $19 million of revenue (Acme United and My Medic).	$18.7M	About 1.0x calculated from the stated figures	Not disclosed

Values and multiples are as stated by the acquirer or reported in the linked source. Value to revenue is our calculation where marked. Company names are the property of their owners and are used for identification. Transactions advised by Benchmark International appear on page 10.

Select Recent Consumer Transactions (Continued)

Buyers in foodservice and consumer services paid for store networks, subscription members, and recurring customer contracts.

ANNOUNCED	TARGET AND ACQUIRER	BUSINESS AND TERMS	STATED VALUE	VALUE TO REVENUE	VALUE TO EARNINGS
MAR 2026 FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION	JETRO RESTAURANT DEPOT ACQUIRED BY SYSCO	Sysco agreed to acquire Jetro Restaurant Depot and its 166 cash-and-carry warehouse stores, and it expects to close by the first calendar quarter of 2027, though members of Congress have asked the FTC to investigate (Sysco and Jetro Restaurant Depot).	About $29.1B enterprise value	Not disclosed	14.6x 2025 operating income, as stated by Sysco
MAR 2026 FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION	FEDERAL INDUSTRIES ACQUIRED BY AERITEK Mill Point Capital	AeriTek bought Federal Industries, a Wisconsin maker of food display cases with $35.7 million of fiscal 2025 revenue, in a carve-out from Standex (Standex on Federal Industries).	About $70M enterprise value	About 2.0x calculated from the stated figures	Not disclosed
APR 2026 FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION	BRESCO ACQUIRED BY SINGER EQUIPMENT CO.	Singer acquired Bresco, a family-led foodservice equipment and supplies dealer in Birmingham, Alabama, with $39.3 million of 2025 sales (Singer Equipment and Bresco). Dealer acquirers rarely disclose price.	Not disclosed	Not disclosed	Not disclosed
FEB 2026 CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL	MISTER CAR WASH ACQUIRED BY LEONARD GREEN & PARTNERS	Leonard Green agreed in February to take Mister Car Wash private at $7.00 per share and completed the purchase on May 19, when the company had about 550 locations and about 2.5 million subscription members (Mister Car Wash and Leonard Green; Mister Car Wash results).	$3.1B enterprise value	2.9x Calculated from full-year 2025 Mister Car Wash financials	8.9x Calculated from full-year 2025 Mister Car Wash financials
MAR 2026 CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL	GUILD GARAGE GROUP ACQUIRED BY OAK HILL CAPITAL	Oak Hill agreed to buy Guild Garage Group, a two-year-old platform assembled from nearly 30 garage door companies, which reportedly generates revenue above $300 million and EBITDA close to $50 million, at a price PitchBook News described as 16 times EBITDA (Oak Hill and Guild Garage Group).	$800M+ as reported	Not disclosed	16x EBITDA, as described by PitchBook News
APR 2026 CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL	ROMEX PEST CONTROL ACQUIRED BY ROLLINS	Rollins acquired Romex Pest Control, a Utah company founded in 2016, and allocated about 89% of the price to customer contracts and goodwill (Rollins and Romex Pest Control; Rollins quarterly filing; PCT Top 100).	$95.7M	2.7x Calculated from PCT Top 100 2025 revenue	Not disclosed

Values and multiples are as stated by the acquirer or reported in the linked source. Value to revenue is our calculation where marked. Three transactions are shown for each of the four sectors on pages 8 and 9.

Benchmark International's Consumer Transactions

Consumer services and retail is the most active sector, and operating companies and platforms bought just over half of the named companies.

SINCE JANUARY 2025

32
consumer transactions closed in the four sectors

110
consumer engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026

9 of 17
named acquirers were operating companies or platforms adding to an existing business

Ranked the leading privately owned sell-side M&A advisor in the world in PitchBook's Q2 2026 Global League Tables (Benchmark International).

BY SECTOR



WHO BOUGHT THE 17 NAMED COMPANIES



Operating companies and platforms adding to an existing business	9
Private equity and private investment firms	6
Individual and entrepreneur-led buyers	2

ANNOUNCED ENGAGEMENTS, BY MONTH OF ANNOUNCEMENT

SEPT 2026 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
GILCO RESTORATION
Fire and water damage restoration, Williamsburg, VA
ACQUIRED BY **Thomasville Restoration**

SEPT 2026 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
EDISON MARTIAL ARTS
Six martial arts academies, New Jersey
ACQUIRED BY **Elevate Youth Development**

JULY 2026 · CONSUMER BRANDS & PRODUCTS
PROJECT ENERGY SAVERS
Educational and community outreach materials
ACQUIRED BY **WRS Group**

JUNE 2026 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
KITTLESON LANDSCAPE
Landscape design and installation, Madison, WI area
ACQUIRED BY **Lancaster Group**

JUNE 2026 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
JAGIMO CORPORATION
Landscape construction and maintenance, Fortuna, CA
ACQUIRED BY **Castleford Group**

MAR 2026 · FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION
TELMARK SALES SOLUTIONS
Sales and marketing brokerage for packaged goods
ACQUIRED BY **Market Performance Group**

MAR 2026 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
STEPFAR INVESTMENTS
Two collision repair centers, Permian Basin, TX
ACQUIRED BY **Classic Collision**

FEB 2026 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
M&M ROOFING
Family-owned residential roofing since 1983, Texas
ACQUIRED BY **Allied Roofing Partners**

JAN 2026 · FOOD & BEVERAGE
FORMULATION TECHNOLOGY
Contract manufacturer of supplements, Oakdale, CA
ACQUIRED BY **AAVIN Private Equity**

DEC 2025 · CONSUMER BRANDS & PRODUCTS
AROCAM
Customized youth sports apparel, Taunton, MA
ACQUIRED BY **Innova Capital**

DEC 2025 · FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION
STIRLING FOOD SYSTEMS
Bulk cooking oil distribution and collection, Ocala, FL
ACQUIRED BY **GreaseCycle**

JULY 2025 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
AFFORDABLE GARAGE DOOR
Garage door sales, installation, and repair, IN and IL
ACQUIRED BY **A.S.A.P. Garage Door Repair**

JUNE 2025 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
GSM WINGS
Sports bar and grill restaurant group, Texas
ACQUIRED BY **GPC Investments**

JUNE 2025 · CONSUMER SERVICES & RETAIL
SOUTHERN POOL DESIGNS
Custom pool design and construction, Central Florida
ACQUIRED BY **an individual investor**

JUNE 2025 · FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION
SMART BUFFET WARE
Buffet and food presentation equipment, Daphne, AL
ACQUIRED BY **Front of House Worldwide**

MAR 2025 · FOOD & BEVERAGE
NOVA SEAFOOD
Seafood importer, processor, and distributor, Portland, ME
ACQUIRED BY **Highwood Harbor**

FEB 2025 · FOODSERVICE & DISTRIBUTION
PALM COAST SALES
Distributor of premium grills and outdoor kitchens, Jupiter, FL
ACQUIRED BY **Fourshore Partners**

Fifteen further consumer transactions closed in the period are not named.

Each tile links to the announcement on benchmarkintl.com, and Benchmark International advised the seller in each. Counts are from Benchmark International's transaction records for January 1, 2025 through September 30, 2026; engagements in progress are shown in aggregate only.

Who Is Buying

Founder- and family-owned consumer businesses draw bids from operating companies, sponsor-backed platforms, and first-time investors in a category.

Public and large private strategics

Buying brands, capacity, and distribution to fill category gaps faster than they could build them.

ACTIVE IN THE 2026 MARKET

Procter & Gamble | Hormel | Clorox | Henkel | Performance Food Group | Rollins | Boyd Group

ACQUIRERS OF BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS

Burris Logistics

Family-owned, regional, and specialist strategics

Operating companies that fund purchases from cash flow and are less sensitive to the cost of debt than a sponsor financing a new platform.

ACTIVE IN THE 2026 MARKET

Rich Products | Sargento | C.H. Guenther | Wasserstrom | Carmela Foods | Bay Crane

ACQUIRERS OF BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS

Front of House Worldwide | GreaseCycle | Hart & Price | Forever Cheese | Ruscan Chem | WRS Group

Consolidators and platforms making add-on acquisitions

Sponsor-backed operating platforms that buy local operators a few locations or routes at a time.

ACTIVE IN THE 2026 MARKET

Rise Baking | Western Smokehouse Partners | El Car Wash | Tidal Wave Auto Spa | Caliber | Ridgeline Roofing | SPS PoolCare | Five Star Breaktime Solutions

ACQUIRERS OF BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS

Classic Collision | A.S.A.P. Garage Door Repair | Allied Roofing Partners | Thomasville Restoration | Elevate Youth Development | Market Performance Group | Diversified Foodservice Supply

Private equity firms and family offices investing directly

Investors making a first purchase in a category. Founders or families kept a stake at Salt & Stone, Tapatio, and Nugredient Solutions.

ACTIVE IN THE 2026 MARKET

Advent International | TSG Consumer Partners | TowerBrook | Acon Investments | Highlander Partners | Guardian Capital Partners | SouthWorth Capital Management

ACQUIRERS OF BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS

AAVIN Private Equity | Innova Capital | Lancaster Group | Castleford Group | Fourshore Partners | GPC Investments | Austin Circle Partners | Longwater Opportunities

Foreign strategics entering the United States

European strategics using acquisitions to enter the United States, as Europastry did through Highland Baking.

ACTIVE IN THE 2026 MARKET

Intersnack | Europastry | Solina

Brand-management firms and individual buyers

Brand-management firms are a further buyer group for apparel and heritage names. Two Benchmark International clients were acquired by individual or entrepreneur-led buyers.

ACTIVE IN THE 2026 MARKET

Authentic Brands Group | WHP Global

ACQUIRERS OF BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS

Highwood Harbor

The individual investor who acquired Southern Pool Designs

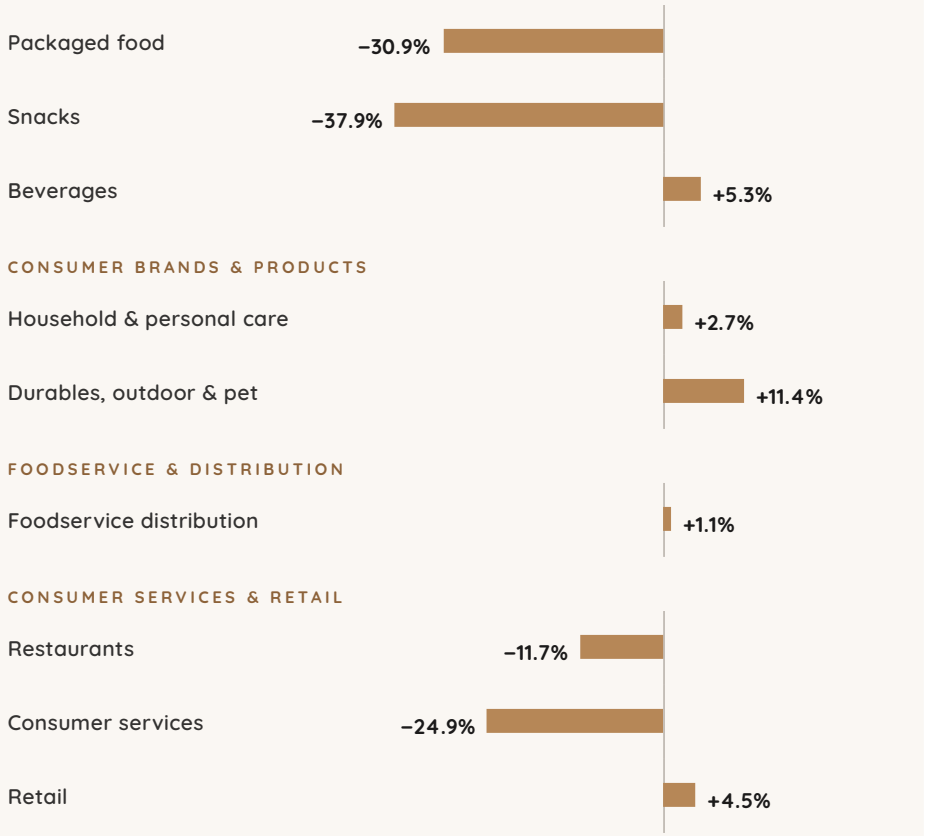
Buyers listed as active are those named in the 2026 transactions covered in the Q4 2026 Consumer report. Acquirers of Benchmark International clients are from announcements on benchmarkintl.com, including earlier engagements. Private equity holds $1.3 trillion of uncommitted capital and about 32,000 unsold portfolio companies (Bain).

Public Company Market Performance

Packaged food shares have fallen about a third in a year, and earnings rose most at foodservice distributors and consumer services companies.

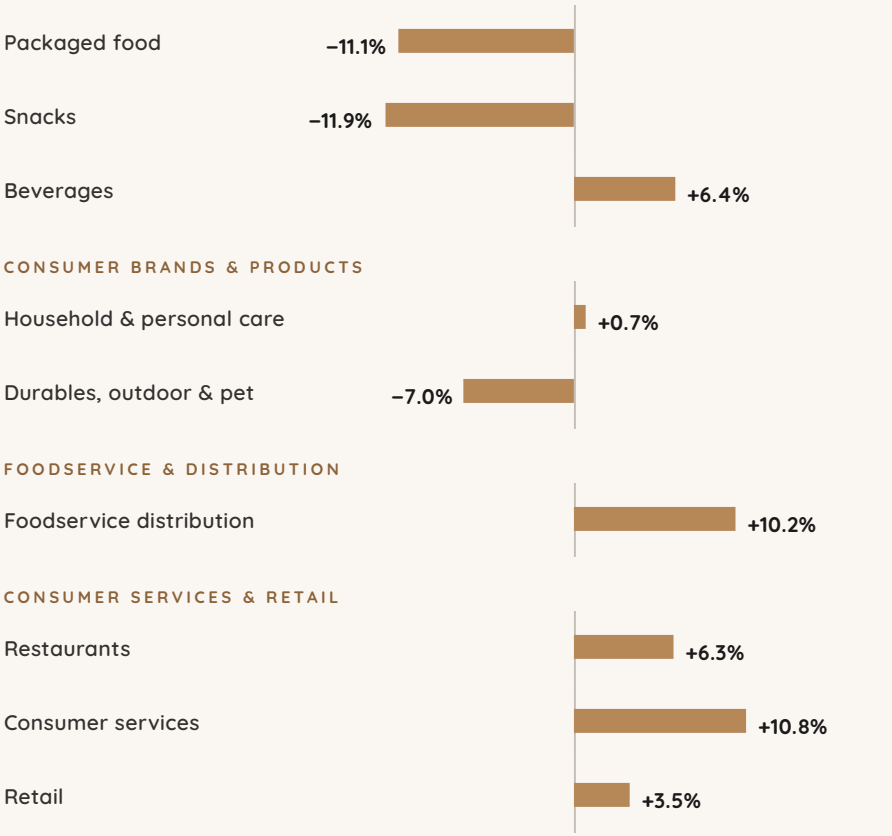
Median change in share price over 52 weeks

Share prices dated October 2 to October 14, 2026, against a year earlier



Median change in EBITDA, latest fiscal year

Reported EBITDA for the latest fiscal year against the year before



WHAT THE MARKET IS PRICING

35 of 57
listed consumer companies trade below their share price of a year ago

11.4x
median enterprise value to trailing EBITDA today, against 14.5x a year ago

9 of 9
peer groups carry a lower median multiple of EBITDA than a year ago

Medians of 57 listed companies in nine peer groups, shown on pages 15 to 17. Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026, and October 14 for Rentokil. EBITDA is as reported. The snacks median sits between Hershey, down 18%, and three smaller companies down 58% to 78%. Multiples cover the 55 companies with comparable readings on both dates.

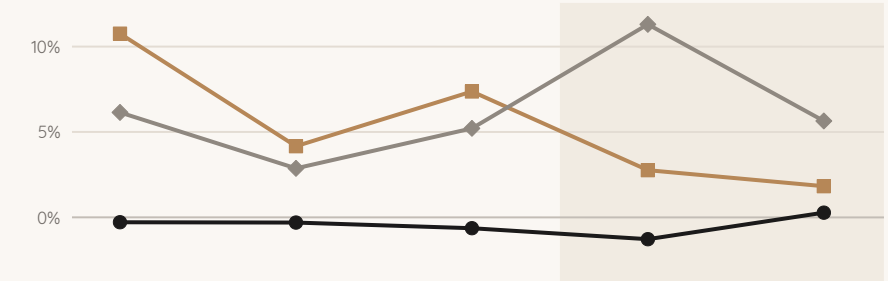
Revenue Growth Trends

Snack, restaurant, and consumer services companies grew fastest in their latest fiscal year, and packaged food revenue has declined three years running.

Food & Beverage

Median revenue growth of the listed peer group, by fiscal year

● Packaged food (8) ■ Snacks (6) ◆ Beverages (6)

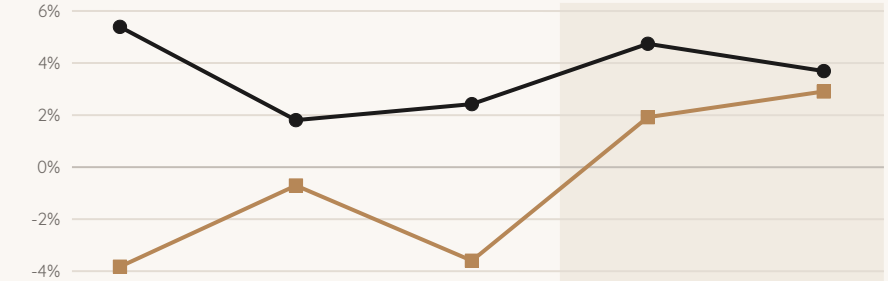


	Two years ago	Prior year	Latest fiscal year	Current year est.	Next year est.
●	−0.3%	−0.3%	−0.7%	−1.3%	+0.3%
■	+10.8%	+4.2%	+7.4%	+2.8%	+1.8%
◆	+6.1%	+2.9%	+5.2%	+11.3%	+5.6%

Consumer Brands & Products

Median revenue growth of the listed peer group, by fiscal year

● Household & personal care (6) ■ Durables, outdoor & pet (6)

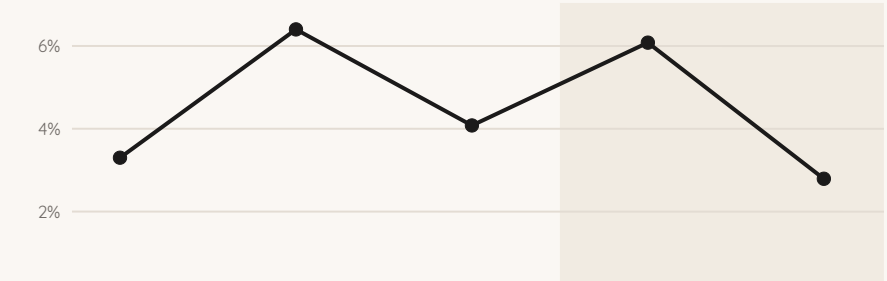


	Two years ago	Prior year	Latest fiscal year	Current year est.	Next year est.
●	+5.4%	+1.8%	+2.4%	+4.7%	+3.7%
■	−3.8%	−0.7%	−3.6%	+1.9%	+2.9%

Foodservice & Distribution

Median revenue growth of the listed peer group, by fiscal year

● Foodservice distribution (5)

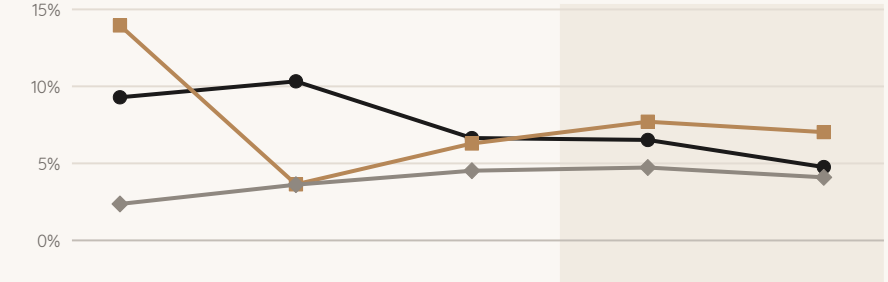


	Two years ago	Prior year	Latest fiscal year	Current year est.	Next year est.
●	+3.3%	+6.4%	+4.1%	+6.1%	+2.8%

Consumer Services & Retail

Median revenue growth of the listed peer group, by fiscal year

● Restaurants (6) ■ Consumer services (7) ◆ Retail (6)



	Two years ago	Prior year	Latest fiscal year	Current year est.	Next year est.
●	+9.3%	+10.3%	+6.6%	+6.5%	+4.8%
■	+14.0%	+3.6%	+6.3%	+7.7%	+7.0%
◆	+2.4%	+3.6%	+4.5%	+4.7%	+4.1%

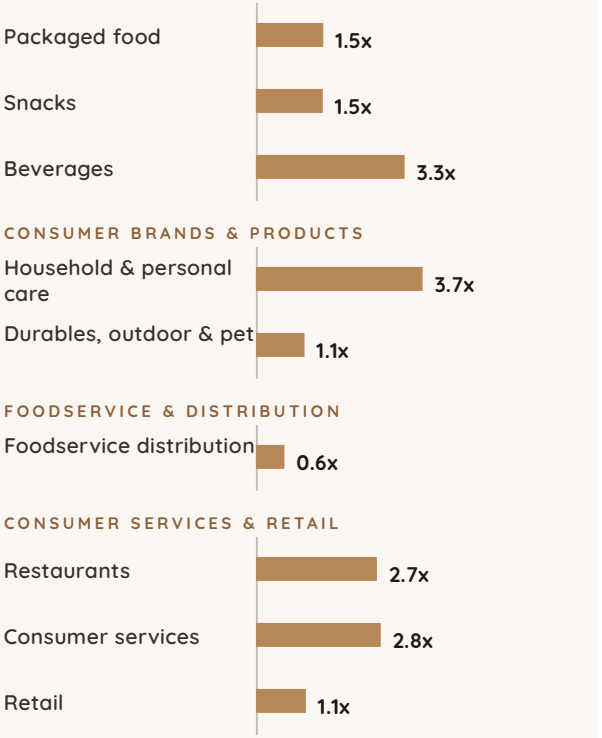
Medians of fiscal-year revenue growth, including acquisitions, with the number of companies in parentheses. Shaded years are analyst consensus, and the rows under each chart give the plotted values in the order of the key. Middleby is left out because its revenue was restated for a spin-off. Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026, and October 14 for Rentokil.

Public Company Valuation Metrics

The median multiple of EBITDA is lower than a year ago in every peer group, and packaged food companies trade near eight times.

Median enterprise value to revenue

Trailing twelve months



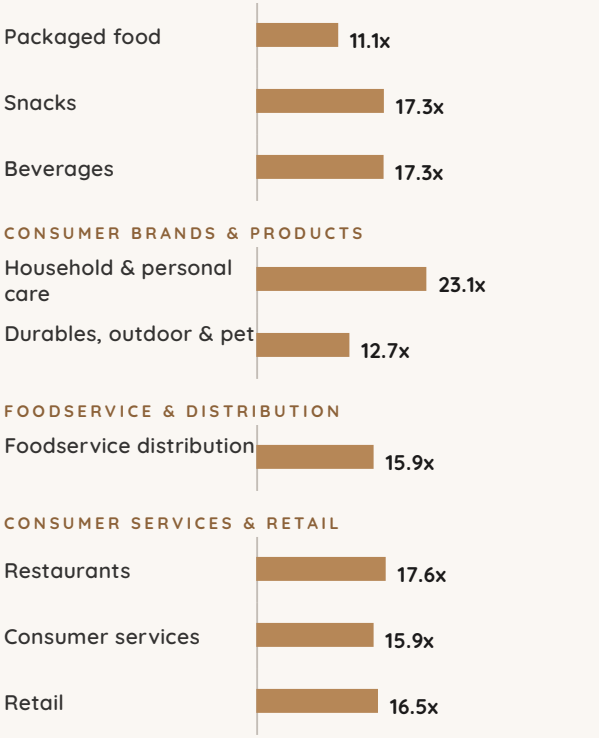
Median enterprise value to EBITDA

Trailing twelve months | A year ago



Median forward price to earnings

Share price to consensus earnings for the next year



DISCLOSED DEAL MULTIPLES SINCE 2025

14.3x
trailing adjusted EBITDA: Kimberly-Clark for Kenvue

14.6x
2025 operating income: Sysco for Jetro Restaurant Depot

12.7x
trailing EBITDA before the earn-out: Church & Dwight for Touchland, calculated

11.0x
EBITDA: Prestige for Breathe Right and other br ands

5.0x
projected EBITDA: HF Foods for Searay Foods

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Medians by peer group, which can move with one or two companies in a group of six. Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026, and October 14 for Rentokil. Multiples use reported EBITDA. The year-ago multiple is the reading four quarter-ends earlier, between late August and November 2025, and June 30, 2025 for Rentokil, which reports half-yearly. Deal multiples are as stated by each acquirer on its own basis.

Public Company Metrics: Food and Beverage

Packaged food companies trade at a median 8.2 times EBITDA. Keurig Dr Pepper's figures include JDE Peet's, and Utz has agreed to be acquired by Intersnack.

COMPANY	TICKER	MARKET CAP ($B)	ENTERPRISE VALUE ($B)	SHARE PRICE, 52 WEEKS	EV / REVENUE	EV / EBITDA TODAY	EV / EBITDA A YEAR AGO	FORWARD P/E	REVENUE GROWTH, TRAILING	EBITDA MARGIN	REVENUE GROWTH, CURRENT YEAR EST.
PACKAGED FOOD											
General Mills	GIS	17.1	30.3	–36.3%	1.66x	8.9x	11.1x	10.4x	–4.5%	18.7%	–4.0%
Conagra Brands	CAG	6.4	13.7	–29.4%	1.22x	7.9x	8.8x	9.2x	–1.8%	15.4%	–4.0%
Kraft Heinz	KHC	25.9	42.3	–13.5%	1.70x	7.7x	8.3x	11.1x	–1.6%	22.1%	–1.3%
Campbell's	CPB	5.6	12.7	–39.6%	1.31x	7.9x	8.8x	11.2x	–5.0%	16.6%	–2.5%
J.M. Smucker	SJM	12.5	19.4	+8.0%	2.12x	8.6x	10.6x	11.6x	+5.1%	24.7%	–1.3%
Hormel Foods	HRL	10.8	12.8	–19.4%	1.05x	10.1x	12.5x	13.0x	+0.7%	10.4%	+0.3%
McCormick	MKC	12.2	16.9	–35.1%	2.18x	11.2x	17.2x	14.5x	+13.2%	19.6%	+15.8%
Post Holdings	POST	3.2	10.5	–32.4%	1.26x	7.3x	8.8x	10.6x	+6.2%	17.2%	+0.2%
Median				**–30.9%**	**1.48x**	**8.2x**	**9.7x**	**11.1x**	**–0.4%**	**18.0%**	**–1.3%**
SNACKS AND BETTER-FOR-YOU											
Mondelez	MDLZ	76.1	96.4	–3.7%	2.42x	15.9x	17.7x	18.5x	+6.9%	15.3%	+4.1%
Hershey	HSY	32.2	37.3	–17.9%	3.07x	13.7x	17.6x	17.3x	+7.7%	22.4%	+5.1%
Utz Brands	UTZ	2.1	3.0	+14.6%	2.08x	33.4x	n.m.	17.7x	+2.0%	6.2%	+3.7%
BellRing Brands	BRBR	0.90	2.0	–77.2%	0.85x	6.1x	10.8x	6.3x	+5.9%	14.1%	+1.8%
Simply Good Foods	SMPL	0.89	1.2	–57.8%	0.87x	5.6x	11.8x	6.0x	–4.5%	15.6%	–6.9%
Vital Farms	VITL	0.39	0.48	–78.1%	0.64x	31.0x	18.8x	n.a.	+16.4%	2.1%	+1.3%
Median				**–37.9%**	**1.48x**	**13.7x**	**17.6x**	**17.3x**	**+6.4%**	**14.7%**	**+2.8%**
BEVERAGES											
Coca-Cola	KO	370.9	398.8	+30.6%	7.95x	23.5x	19.7x	25.4x	+6.5%	33.9%	+3.8%
PepsiCo	PEP	169.3	211.8	–11.2%	2.18x	11.2x	13.9x	14.5x	+5.6%	19.5%	+5.3%
Keurig Dr Pepper	KDP	41.9	73.9	+21.8%	n.m.	n.m.	12.3x	12.7x	+27.5%	23.9%	+58.5%
Monster Beverage	MNST	84.1	80.7	+27.8%	8.73x	27.5x	25.6x	35.1x	+20.4%	31.8%	+17.3%
Celsius	CELH	6.8	6.9	–54.4%	2.28x	10.3x	39.5x	20.0x	+82.9%	22.0%	+26.1%
Constellation Brands	STZ	20.2	30.4	–15.0%	3.28x	8.8x	9.7x	9.9x	–4.3%	37.5%	–0.7%
Median				**+5.3%**	**3.28x**	**11.2x**	**19.7x**	**17.3x**	**+13.4%**	**27.9%**	**+11.3%**

Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026; share prices are dated October 2 to 7. Multiples and margins use reported trailing EBITDA. n.m. marks a figure that is not comparable and is left out of the median; n.a. is not available. Year-ago multiples are four quarter-ends earlier, and multiple medians use companies with both readings.

Public Company Metrics: Consumer Brands and Foodservice

Household and personal care companies hold the highest multiples of the nine groups. Middleby's figures reflect the July spin-off of its food processing business.

COMPANY	TICKER	MARKET CAP ($B)	ENTERPRISE VALUE ($B)	SHARE PRICE, 52 WEEKS	EV / REVENUE	EV / EBITDA TODAY	EV / EBITDA A YEAR AGO	FORWARD P/E	REVENUE GROWTH, TRAILING	EBITDA MARGIN	REVENUE GROWTH, CURRENT YEAR EST.
HOUSEHOLD AND PERSONAL CARE											
Procter & Gamble	PG	346.6	371.7	–0.8%	4.26x	15.0x	15.7x	21.3x	+3.3%	28.4%	+2.1%
Colgate-Palmolive	CL	68.7	75.1	+10.5%	3.57x	15.1x	15.0x	21.5x	+5.3%	23.7%	+5.0%
Church & Dwight	CHD	22.9	25.1	+9.8%	4.03x	18.5x	16.9x	24.7x	+2.7%	21.8%	+0.6%
Clorox	CLX	10.1	15.6	–32.2%	2.31x	13.6x	14.5x	14.5x	–5.4%	17.0%	+13.6%
Estee Lauder	EL	33.8	39.6	+6.3%	2.63x	16.1x	18.4x	28.1x	+5.1%	16.3%	+4.5%
e.l.f. Beauty	ELF	6.1	6.7	–23.8%	3.78x	31.8x	48.1x	33.6x	+31.2%	11.9%	+20.3%
Median				**+2.7%**	**3.68x**	**15.6x**	**16.3x**	**23.1x**	**+4.2%**	**19.4%**	**+4.7%**
DURABLES, OUTDOOR AND PET											
Central Garden & Pet	CENT	2.5	2.9	+22.9%	0.94x	8.6x	7.6x	13.9x	–1.2%	11.0%	–3.7%
Spectrum Brands	SPB	1.8	2.3	+45.2%	0.78x	8.0x	7.2x	14.2x	+0.8%	9.8%	+2.1%
YETI	YETI	2.9	3.1	+15.2%	1.60x	10.6x	10.0x	12.7x	+6.2%	15.1%	+7.6%
Mattel	MAT	4.6	6.8	–11.8%	1.23x	10.4x	9.4x	11.9x	+2.9%	11.9%	+6.0%
Newell Brands	NWL	2.4	7.9	+7.6%	1.09x	8.7x	10.1x	8.7x	–2.0%	12.5%	+1.8%
Traeger	COOK	0.14	0.51	–10.0%	1.05x	9.1x	11.0x	n.m.	–16.3%	11.6%	–20.2%
Median				**+11.4%**	**1.07x**	**8.9x**	**9.7x**	**12.7x**	**–0.2%**	**11.7%**	**+1.9%**
FOODSERVICE DISTRIBUTION AND EQUIPMENT											
Sysco	SYY	38.0	51.3	–4.4%	0.61x	11.4x	12.1x	15.3x	+3.9%	5.3%	+6.1%
US Foods	USFD	20.9	26.3	+27.8%	0.65x	14.7x	13.3x	18.6x	+3.8%	4.4%	+5.2%
Performance Food Group	PFGC	14.8	22.5	–8.6%	0.35x	13.2x	15.3x	16.5x	+7.4%	2.6%	+13.0%
Chefs' Warehouse	CHEF	4.6	5.4	+105.3%	1.22x	20.5x	14.8x	40.8x	+11.2%	5.9%	+10.5%
United Natural Foods	UNFI	2.7	5.7	+6.6%	0.18x	9.0x	10.6x	13.2x	–2.0%	2.0%	+1.3%
Middleby	MIDD	4.7	6.6	–25.2%	1.96x	9.4x	16.5x	14.3x	n.m.	20.7%	n.m.
Median				**+1.1%**	**0.63x**	**12.3x**	**14.1x**	**15.9x**	**+3.9%**	**4.9%**	**+6.1%**

Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026; share prices are dated October 2 to 7. Multiples and margins use reported trailing EBITDA. n.m. marks a figure that is not comparable and is left out of the median; n.a. is not available. Year-ago multiples are four quarter-ends earlier, and multiple medians use companies with both readings.

Public Company Metrics: Restaurants, Services, and Retail

Rollins, Planet Fitness, and Boyd Group shares have each fallen by about half in a year while their revenue kept growing.

COMPANY	TICKER	MARKET CAP ($B)	ENTERPRISE VALUE ($B)	SHARE PRICE, 52 WEEKS	EV / REVENUE	EV / EBITDA TODAY	EV / EBITDA A YEAR AGO	FORWARD P/E	REVENUE GROWTH, TRAILING	EBITDA MARGIN	REVENUE GROWTH, CURRENT YEAR EST.
RESTAURANTS											
Darden Restaurants	DRI	22.8	31.1	+4.0%	2.35x	14.6x	14.2x	17.5x	+8.1%	16.0%	+3.7%
Texas Roadhouse	TXRH	10.7	11.6	−2.0%	1.87x	16.5x	16.4x	22.7x	+9.9%	11.3%	+11.3%
Chipotle	CMG	39.1	43.8	−26.0%	3.53x	19.3x	24.0x	24.4x	+7.3%	18.3%	+9.3%
McDonald's	MCD	164.1	217.8	−21.3%	7.88x	14.6x	19.0x	17.6x	+6.3%	53.9%	+4.8%
Domino's Pizza	DPZ	10.2	15.2	−27.0%	2.98x	14.6x	20.6x	15.2x	+5.2%	20.4%	+4.9%
Brinker International	EAT	7.8	9.5	+47.8%	1.65x	11.3x	9.6x	14.2x	+7.9%	14.6%	+8.2%
Median				**−11.7%**	**2.67x**	**14.6x**	**17.7x**	**17.6x**	**+7.6%**	**17.2%**	**+6.5%**
CONSUMER AND ROUTE-BASED SERVICES											
Rollins	ROL	15.1	16.1	−46.4%	4.00x	18.2x	34.8x	25.2x	+9.9%	22.0%	+8.7%
Frontdoor	FTDR	5.4	5.9	+15.5%	2.75x	11.5x	11.4x	15.9x	+9.2%	24.0%	+5.1%
Driven Brands	DRVN	2.0	4.0	−24.9%	2.06x	9.8x	16.0x	9.1x	+15.4%	21.0%	+7.7%
Rentokil Initial	RTO	10.1	13.8	−24.0%	1.94x	11.1x	14.5x	13.7x	+3.3%	17.6%	+4.8%
Planet Fitness	PLNT	3.2	5.8	−56.4%	4.41x	9.9x	20.3x	12.3x	+11.6%	44.4%	+15.0%
Service Corporation Intl	SCI	10.5	15.5	−8.3%	3.57x	11.8x	12.5x	17.3x	+2.9%	30.3%	+3.6%
Boyd Group Services	BGSI	2.2	4.2	−52.7%	1.15x	13.5x	21.3x	18.9x	+17.3%	8.5%	+29.8%
Median				**−24.9%**	**2.75x**	**11.5x**	**16.0x**	**15.9x**	**+9.9%**	**22.0%**	**+7.7%**
RETAIL											
Walmart	WMT	858.3	921.9	+5.4%	1.25x	20.9x	20.2x	35.7x	+6.2%	6.0%	+5.6%
Costco	COST	419.0	406.2	+3.7%	1.33x	28.1x	30.0x	41.1x	+10.1%	4.7%	+8.4%
Target	TGT	69.8	83.6	+72.3%	0.78x	9.7x	7.2x	16.6x	+2.0%	8.0%	+5.2%
Kroger	KR	35.4	57.9	−7.5%	0.39x	7.2x	7.9x	10.9x	+1.6%	5.4%	+2.2%
Dollar General	DG	27.1	41.3	+23.3%	0.95x	11.6x	11.9x	14.9x	+4.8%	8.2%	+4.3%
Tractor Supply	TSCO	17.0	23.3	−40.0%	1.48x	12.1x	17.9x	16.4x	+4.0%	12.3%	+2.8%
Median				**+4.5%**	**1.10x**	**11.8x**	**14.9x**	**16.5x**	**+4.4%**	**7.0%**	**+4.7%**

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Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026; share prices are dated October 2 to 7, and October 14 for Rentokil. Multiples and margins use reported trailing EBITDA. n.m. marks a figure that is not comparable and is left out of the median; n.a. is not available. Year-ago multiples are four quarter-ends earlier (June 30, 2025 for Rentokil, which reports half-yearly), and multiple medians use companies with both readings.

Demand and Cost Indicators

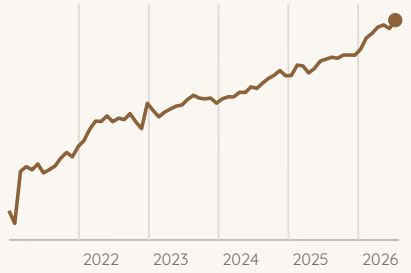
Spending is rising in dollars while sentiment falls, food manufacturers' selling prices are flat, and diesel costs two thirds more than a year ago.

Retail and food services sales

Monthly, seasonally adjusted, US Census Bureau

$773.9B
Aug 2026

+6.0%
over one year



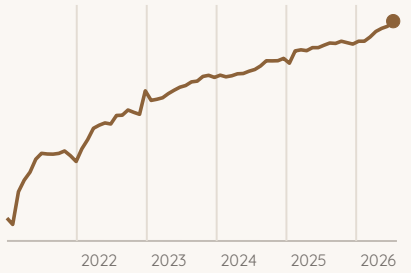
Source: FRED, series MRTSSM44X72USS; Census advance release

Food services and drinking places sales

Monthly, seasonally adjusted, US Census Bureau

$105.1B
Aug 2026

+5.8%
over one year



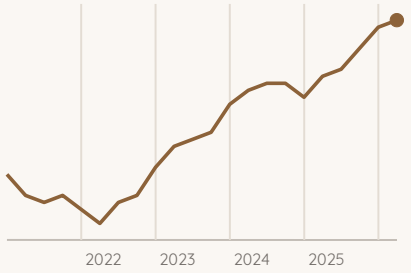
Source: FRED, series MRTSSM722USS; Census advance release

E-commerce share of retail sales

Quarterly, seasonally adjusted, US Census Bureau

17.1%
Q2 2026

+0.8 pts
over one year



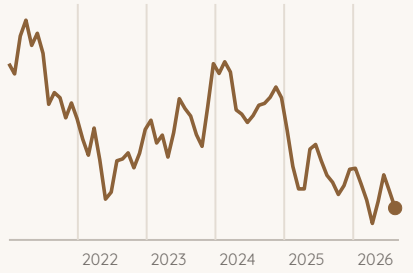
Source: FRED, series ECOMPCTSA

Consumer sentiment

University of Michigan index, monthly

48.1
Sep 2026

–7.0 pts
over one year



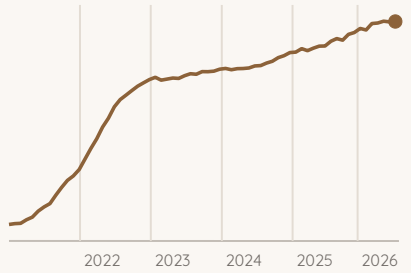
Source: FRED, series UMCSENT; Surveys of Consumers

Food at home prices

Consumer price index, seasonally adjusted, 1982–84 = 100

321.3
Aug 2026

+2.1%
over one year



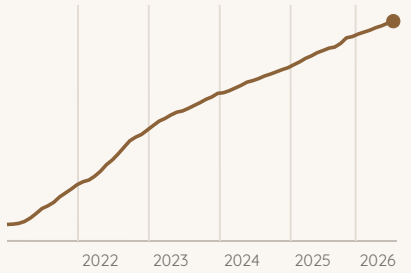
Source: FRED, series CUSR0000SAF11

Food away from home prices

Consumer price index, seasonally adjusted, 1982–84 = 100

397.9
Aug 2026

+3.4%
over one year



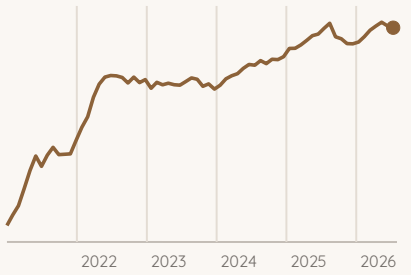
Source: FRED, series CUSR0000SEFV

Food manufacturing producer prices

Producer price index, Dec 1984 = 100, Bureau of Labor Statistics

273.0
Aug 2026

+0.1%
over one year



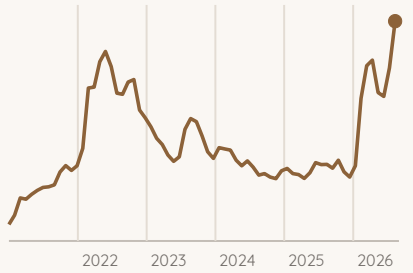
Source: FRED, series PCU311311

Diesel price

US on-highway retail price per gallon, monthly average

$6.29
Sep 2026

+67.8%
over one year



Source: FRED, series GASDESM

Each series runs from January 2021. August retail figures are the Census advance estimate, and September sentiment is from the Surveys of Consumers. The consumer price series have no October 2025 reading, and the unadjusted food-at-home increase reported for August is 2.2%.

03

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20 Connect with our team

21 Important disclosures

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Shannon Hess

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01 Share a few details
Tell us about your company and what you are considering. Everything you share is held in strict confidence.

02 Talk with a Managing Director
A senior member of the team will set up a private conversation at a time that suits you.

03 See your options clearly
Understand the paths available, from a strategic sale to a merger or change-of-control transaction, and what each could mean for you.

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Ranking based on PitchBook's Q2 2026 Global League Tables, as published at benchmarkintl.com. Team as listed on the Middle Market site in October 2026.

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